

Never Smoking At Night
Again

Author: Alden Esterhuizen

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Dedication

*For those who keep the
lights on at night.*

The start

The morning of June 16th 2017, I got woken up by the ringing of my phone, on the other end was my boss, with a tone of fury and despair he asked "DID YOU LOOK OVER THE FINAL SCHEMATIC AND CALCULATIONS OF THE Nerodrive?", the nerodrive is a device that we invented as a way to better communicate with animals, specifically chimps, "No, That has to go through James.", with my statement he got more furies, he went on a rant about "No-one knows what is going on at this damn company", all I said was that I would be on call if he needs help and hung up the phone. Getting out of bed always seemed to be the most difficult part of the day, well for me, but my wife on the other hand seemed to have a need to be out of bed and busy doing whatever it is that she does, as early as the rooster crows. Once out of bed I

walk to the bathroom to wash the sleep out of my eye, turning the tap, placing my hands beneath the stream of icy-cold water, the feeling of alertness and awakesness jolts through my body as I splash it onto my face. Walking back to the bedroom I could hear the sound of neighbors mowing their grass, the sound of birds singing, dogs barking, all the sound you would typically find in a well-off suburban neighbourhood. Getting dressed it seemed as if for some reason today, I could feel every fiber, every piece of loose fabric rub against my skin. Once seated at the kitchen table, I looked around at what was happening, the boys, Jake and Adam both 4, running around with the styrofoam swords that we had bought them days ago, yelling about some treasure the other one apparently stole, my wife was in her best mood, the sounds of

clinking pots, spatula scraping against the pan as she made pancakes, her subtle humming that seemed to always calm me. Getting handed my plate I called the boys, "Jake, Adam! Breakfast is ready!", they came storming in, "Slow down or you could hurt yourself.", I told them, they seemed to glare at me as if I had somehow interfered with the best running of their lives, after all was settled down we started eating, again sounds sounder more clear, the sound of the syrup being poured, forks and knives scraping plates, the sound of the occasional open mouth chewing, clearly my wife saw that the sounds were becoming to overwhelming, "Remember", she started "It is going to take time to get used to the new hearing aids", Yet you would think that after nearly 2 weeks my body would have gotten used to the new

massive amounts of sounds, and the detail of it flooding my brain, short-circuiting my thoughts every time I tried to focus, with the sounds starting to intensify I saw no other choice but to stand up and excuse myself before I would completely break. Slowly walking away from the torture of today's breakfast I headed to my study to complete some of my work, this being one of the many benefits I have of being a "checker" at my job, I can work at any time from anywhere with a data or wifi connection, as long as I get the job done before the due date I am being praised in a way that has allowed me to earn nearly an 8 figure salary on 3 years. But the way I see it, if it were not for my job's great medical benefits I would be on my old hearing aids, the same ones that I had since my brother and I's accident or what my parents called

“The worst way to teach ourselves a lesson”. That happened nearly 29 years ago, we were visiting our grandparents home, the cabin my grandfather built deep in the nearby forest, we helped him build it, chopped down each tree that was used, usually going home smelling of pine and wood dust and of course smelling of the scent that showed how much was done aka, sweat, when we went visiting the woods seemed to greet us with the welcoming scent of grass, pine and the same scent that we were told was cow manure but we never did see or hear any cows, getting closer to the cabin we saw the roof stick out first, and finally after mere seconds we saw it, our hard work and days spent building, was right there with our grandparents sitting on the porch, grandpa with his cup of coffee and grandma knitting with that same melody being

hummed and pair of glasses that had to have been decades old, we practically jumped out of the car once it came to a halt, the sound of the doors clicking open and our small bodies hitting the dry autumn leafs with a satisfying crunch, running into our grandpa's arms almost throwing him from the chair, we chuckled in glee as he hoisted us up, as for a 79 year old he was what other younger men could only dream of, grandad was a pro tri-athlete, setting multiple records, and as a result of years of training and still doing heavy lifting for his building and hobbies, his body seemed to retain that training, if not improve it more. With him holding us in the air, saying "I missed you boys so much", placing us down softly we went to grandma with the same excitement, yet when she saw us getting hasty she gave us a glare that once stopped a

army colonel when he started to raise his voice, reasons still unclear, we stopped and walked over, greeted as we were taught and she gave us what you might know as a “grandmothers-kiss”, that sensation of spit and witness that is left behind once it was done, having you trying to wipe off what you can. Getting settled for lunch, a feast we could smell from outside, the smell of chicken, gravy, mashed potatoes, and all that would be on a sunday feast, we got settled, made our plates, and started having usual conversation, the normal questions “What are you up to”, “how’s school going” and so on, the lunch was going as well as one could think, until my dad asked what set off what can described as a force that silenced every living thing within a 2 km radius, even me and my brother both knew to stay quiet, grandma shooting

daggers and mom, almost pleading whispers that he should not push. Grandad looked at my dad, looked at us , at mom and finally at grandma, slowly rising from his chair, the only sound was the sound of Charles still eating as if the food was going to run away, the sound of his fork occasionally hitting the plate with force that could break it and the high pitched screech that it would cause. Grandad asked dad with a calmness that even we knew meant that he was serious, them stepping outside, mom and grandma stepping into the kitchen and grandma giving us permission to go look around in the attic for any thing that might entertain us, unfortunately for them they did not say what we can and cant use to entertain ourselves, as we found a massive airhorn and me and Charles being the kids we were we had the

idea, "Lets see who can go longer with it going off in their ear" Charles said, I accepted this challenge with a seriousness that would make people ask if I was ok, "1,2,3" he counted the it started the loud blare started off just loud and slowly it got softer and softer and softer till it was gone, after what seemed to be a minute I saw my dad and grandpa storming into the room, the dust once again being visible in the ray of sunlight,grabbing it out of his hand, throwing it to the other side ot the room, grandad getting down on his knees talking to him and dad, he knelt in front of me, and started talking only then did I realise I could not hear, only see his lips moving and occasionally making out a word, I started crying while knowing what I was saying being unable to hear it. That visit was cut short and I ended up getting taken to the hospital, the doctor

gave the new to my parents and they wrote to me, "He wont be able to hear again without assistance",m I was devastated but not long after I got a pair of hearing aids, allowing me to hear without a problem, but what I miss most about those were the fact that every sound did not sound as it does now, back then it had a weird effect where louder noises were silenced a bit and quieter noises were amplified as a method to allow my body to adjust and I kept it that way, and as I made obvious the newer ones were not as kind to my body, I had to get the new ones as the older ones simply were old and finally gave up and as one would expect I had to got to a doctor to get my ears checked and new one prescribed, sitting in that waiting room, the smell of something that one cant place in their memories, the uncomfortable

chairs, the squeaking sound of persons moving on the plastic covered couches, the cold air despite it being winter, the sound of keyboards being used and finally the dread of waiting for your name to be called despite knowing he is going to help you, you still feel anxious, "Mr.Jake", he calls, My wife taps my shoulder, I stand up not being able to hear the rest, I feel the vibration of every step as I walk nearer the doctors office, my wife just behind me. Sitting down he talk to my wife and I just point to my ears, once he understood he pointed to the table he has and showed me where to sit, through my jeans I could feel the coldness of the table, the doctor grabbed something, show with his hands that he was going to check my ears, after an amount of time I am sure was just a few seconds, I felt some pressure go into my ear and just as

quickly leave as it had started, he showed he was done and pointed me back to my seat, after a conversation with my wife and me paying the expensive bill, I was told by my wife that in a few days we were to come back so he could give and assist with the new hearing aids. 3 days later, my wife got the call that we could come back, driving there I all I could think of between the feeling of the car vibrating and the wind blowing in my face was the thought of again being able to hear my wife and children's voices, despite being told that with these I would have to adjust as they are newer and only amplifies that which it receives, despite that warning I did not think it would be this big of a problem, where the smallest sounds became a weapon against my ears and ability to think without losing focus, nevertheless that is how I got these

and why I had to walk away from that breakfast. Days after again at the table, eating breakfast, still the sounds were a bother but I managed to force myself to stay to get used to them, the usual breakfast sounds followed but was suddenly interrupted by the sound of our old landline, my wife got up, the chair scraping the floor and creaking with the sound of her weight being taken off, the sound of her slippers clapping against the tiles, the sound of the phone being unhooked, her greeting the person on the other end, the conversation would go on as usual with her normal uh-hu and mhm's until it went silent, "Jake" she said in an almost sympathetic tone, standing up, taking the phone, "Hello" I managed to say, from the other side I heard Charles, "Grandad, died last night, they think it was a heart attack", "Thanks" I

said, hooking the phone back, the sound of the click being the only thing I managed to hear, looking at my wife and the boys, my wife looking at me with that expression that says “Well? Tell me what was said”, the only thing I could manage to say in a slow and careful voice, “Grandad died”, by say that it’s as if the gates were opened to my tears, they start flowing just as a flash flood, the kids seemed to notice but paid no mind to it at all, my wife hugged me in her soft voice she kept repeating that it would be okay, that she's sorry and that she's there for me, tasting salt by this point, I excuse myself, heading to the bathroom to wash my face and get ready to go to my office and continue with the project that I had been assigned. After hours of work I finally decided to take a break, get some fresh air, eat and interact with my

kids. Walking into the backyard I got hit with the scent of trees, freshly cut grass, the sound of planes above, dogs nearby, cars passing by with the same “zoom” that we all know and recognize, going back into the kitchen, made myself and the kids each a PB and J sandwich, the plates clattered against each other as I carry them to the living room where they were busy building a pillow fort, although they never could seem to figure out how to build a working door, I approach and give them each their plate, I sit on the floor with them, the sound of my clothes rubbing against the fluffy carpet that my wife somehow convinced me that we needed it, that it was better than any other carpet out there, and it is as if my wife has an extra scent for when we eat on her carpet, her “Need that” carpet, yelling came from her knitting/working

station, "If you let one crumb get on my carpet!" So I did what any reasonable husband would do, I finished with my sandwich, waited for the boys to finish theirs, took the plates, stacking them on top of one another with that sharp clink sound, walked back to the kitchen, washed them and proceeded to get the vacuum from the closet. Opening the closet, dust seemed to target my nose, making me sneeze, moving some boxes, grabbing the vacuum and cleaning up where we ate on the carpet, put it back and went outside to get some more fresh air before going back to work. Whilst standing outside my phone rang, vibrating in my pocket, I took it out and saw that Charles was calling, with a knot in my throat I answered, silence filled the surroundings and the call, it was all broken when he simply asked, "How have you been doing?", keeping my

voice steady I told him, "The new hearing aids were not that bad but ever since the news it seems as if all it even worse, and you?", "Fine" he said, "Would you like to come up to my place then we can drive to the cabin and clear it out ,see what we want to keep?", "Sure" I said, knowing that once there we would not want to come back or spend all our time, not looking through everything but to just sit and remember. We continued to talk for more or less 10 minutes, confirming what time we should leave, when I should arrive at his place, all those things. That night I, while getting ready told my wife the plan, she seemed hesitant at first but I think she could see the hope it gave me in my eyes when I brought it up, in a dramatic sigh, "Enjoy it" she said, sliding into bed the softness of the covers seemed strange, I never realised how soft they

were, even the pillows, no everything seemed softer, I told my wife this and she looked at me with a look that told me that she thought I was crazy, maybe I was, maybe the death of grandad finally pushed me over the edge, the tall edge we all were meant to stay from, to keep us from falling down with a strong current keeping us from crashing, to break us slowly over an unknown amount of time, and my time is growing nearer and nearer to the end. The following morning I awoke to the sound of my phone buzzing on my nightstand, eyes half awake I swung my body to the edge of the bed, silencing the alarm, walking to the bathroom, the same routine I had for the past 3 years, the same breakfast, same sounds same everything. The week seemed to be moving at a pace slower than a snail, the work seemed more, everything seemed

to take much longer, the watch ticked slower, the dogs seemed to move at a slower pace, the car drove slower, "I'm going mad" I thought, just as it seemed that I would also start to move slower, standing in the backyard, the phone rung again, Chales displayed the caller ID, I answered, "See you tomorrow", that's all that he said before hanging up, I forgot, I completely forgot what we had agreed on. A sudden rush of excitement and sorrow rushed through my body, in a flash I was in my room not even packing just throwing clothes into a random bag, it might have been one of my wife's old duffel bags but I did not care, the excitement of seeing my brother and the thought of seeing that cabin again leveled each other, only then only in that moment did it register with me, I had not been to any reading of a will, I started to

take my phone out to call my brother but decided against it, "I'll ask him when I see him tomorrow." was the thought I had, at dinner everything seemed normal, plates getting scraped with forks and knives, kids having to be reminded to eat with their mouths closed, the normal dinner conversation, in the shower the water despite being steaming hot I did not feel a thing, I spent an unknown amount of time in there and only snapped out of whatever auto pilot I was in when my wife wanted her turn to shower and poked my shoulder with her sharp nails and waited for me to get out. Once back in the bedroom I clothed myself, and lay in bed, staring at the ceiling, only the sound I could focus on was my wife humming in the shower, the sound of water being spit out of the shower head, hitting the shower curtain and floor,

the sound of shampoo or body wash being clicked open and clicked close again. After what felt like 20 minutes the shower turned off, I heard her wet feet hit the cold floor with that splat we all know, the sound of her feeling the cold, the towel being used to dry herself, the towel being tied around her, the door handle turning the door creaking open, seeing her even after the time we were married I still got butterflies when I saw her, seeing her in such a vulnerable state, it gave me the same feeling as the day we stood under that arch and both said "I do", the same feeling as our first kiss, the same feeling as when we got to watch the kids take their first steps, the same feeling that was dormant for during the darkest time. Shortly after I was fast asleep, sleeping as a baby cradled in his mothers arms, the following morning I felt refreshed, ready

to take on anything that might come my way. The drive to my brother was nothing more than a silent car ride with the occasional talking on the radio and the sound of other cars passing by, driving for hours nearing hour 4 I got to the front gate of the estate in which he lived, just as myself he also designs and over looks things, he just does it at a much larger and more expensive scale, running the bell to house #45 his voice pop through the speaker, "Hello", I greet him and the gate swings open with the sound of metal creaking, driving in I seemed out of place among the very wealthy, my old car between the newer electric models, getting nearer to his home I knew what to expect yet every time I see that massive mansion of a home atop the hill I stop to wonder why I never swapped to a job such as his. My car stopped in his driveway,

the tires screeched, pulling up the hand brake that normal click followed until I shut off the car and there it was, me in the silence staring at the front door. I finally got out of my car, closed the door and heard the click, locked it with that same click, walked up to the door with my shoes clicking against the hard tar driveway, knocking on the door I counted, "1,2,3,fou..." as I was about to reach 4 the door swung open, there he was, Charles, looking as if he aged by a decade, "Come in" he said in a distant and hollow voice, pointing to the inside of his home, stepping inside I saw classic artworks worth more than my house, statues that had to have taken months to sculpt, getting shown to my room I saw more painting in the hallway and once in the guest bedroom, a painting above the bed as well, depicting a woman and man in nude

running through what looked like a field of corn, he must have seen the shock on my face and I assume felt the need to say that "I make a lot of money, some might say too much so I spend it, trying to fill the void where one might place someone they love, but how can I love them back if I don't know if they want me for me or for my money", I stayed silent, after a few seconds I asked him what he wanted to do for dinner, silence, "I can cook" I said, still silence, recognising this as the same response he has when he feels sad/depressed having no way to express it, I patted him on the shoulder and asked for directions to the kitchen, getting to the kitchen just as the rest of the house it is massive, every possible type of food you would need to make a good meal, the best knives, the best brands except a small knife stuck

to the fridge, the knife we made together under the guidance of grandad, it might not be the sharpest but it is our work, his work, his name carved into the birch wood used for the handle. He saw me staring, "I tried to use the knife but I can't, it's too dull", not knowing what he meant, I did what I did best after learning from grandma and my wife, I started looking through each drawer, each cupboard, every rack in the fridge and freezer, until I found all that would be needed to make grandmas famous, simple and delicious home made Bruschetta al Pomodoro topped with Coq au Vin, it might sound all fancy and thing only the rich would but it's just bread with chicken, I threw that in to make me sound like a fantastic chef, telling him this seemed to get him out of the state he was in, he smiled and told me "Every time I eat at an

expensive restaurant the names confuse me so I always settle for a smaller family owned restaurant, their honest and dont put a price tag on a fancy name.”, “Even so” I said, explaining that even the price of the more expensive restaurants aren't just related to the price they are almost to the limitedness of it, the ingredients, in the middle of it he simply said, “but the chapter places make you feel at home, expensive ones see you as just another customer.”, I never thought that despite his massive fortune he would favour feeling over exclusivity, the same man, once boy, that wanted to be part of all the secret clubs and organisations, never thought that he would be such a humble guy. Eating in silence only my fork and knife scratching my plate, “He had practice” I thought, he without a complaint once we finished took both our plates

and eating utensils put them in the sink and made us both a simple yet delicious looking ice-cream bowl if you could call it that, taking a bite it literally melts in your mouth, a taste like no other, "What is this?" I ask while stuffing my mouth, a slight grin appears on his face "It's pistachio ice cream with mint chocolate mixed in.", him looking at me as an older brother glad to see his younger brother getting what he likes or something new that he loves, the same glance he had as my best man at my wedding when he gave the ring, you get the idea, the same look as that he had at any big milestone in my life where I was gladly celebrating. Looking at his eyes they seemed to be glad but still missing something, that something I think was the feeling of grandad being able to help in any sad time, but now that the sad time what because of

his death, who was there to help him, as he was always the one that even though showed fewer emotion, he was more prone to easily let sadness take him into a spiral of self-hatred and sorrow. That week that I stayed with him leading up to the drive to the cabin was quiet, the same quite that would make a parent start thinking that their kids are getting up to no good, the same quite that's there before the storm, and how right that feeling would be, I just did not know it yet and neither did those who I tried to tell. 9 days after first arriving at his home we left early that morning, the feeling in that room getting our things ready for the 3 hour drive was deafening, the same for the first hour of the drive, as if a switch flipped when one song played on the radio, one song we knew from our childhood as it was still new when we were near

the ages of 14 and 15, Saturday Sun by Vance Joy, without a seconds hesitation we started singing, hitting every high note, every beat, the atmosphere seemed to change to a warmer and pleasant feeling, even after the song ended, we ended up talking about the memories we had with grandad, specifically how he taught us to survive and live off the wilderness, the ride was filled with chatter, the occasional song, sound of cars passing and the sound of the wind blowing in our ears. We needed to stop somewhere between the final 1-1.5 hours of the drive, "Damit, the tires flat" He yelled looking at it once he got out, getting out and walking around I saw a massive screw in the wheel, calling a repair truck was a hassle, no one wanted to get us, luckily we had a good heart samaritan who offered to tow us to the next gas

station, without a thought we agreed. Getting there was not fun, the wheel kept making a clicking sound that we could not find, even after taking the wheel off only the band seemed damaged, no sign of anything that would make a sound. Getting the help of an attendant we jacked up the car, put on the spare, and filled the tank. Getting back on the road we continued with our joyful mood, singing to the songs on the radio, despite not even knowing the lyrics, as we closed in on the forest where the cabin was built, the roads grew quieter, less populated, only passing 2 cars in the final 30km. At last we got to the entrance of the forest when the sun was at its peak, blazing us with its heat, we got out of the car, the trees grew nearer the path, no car can pass, stepping outside I heard the crunch of acorns, dried leaves and rocks, stepping in front

of the car looking at the forest it seemed to greet us as if it had waited for us, as if it knew why we came, only the sound of our shoes and the cracking underneath, birds in the distance and the wind blowing is what was heard, the smell of pine, and nature filled the air. Taking a step to the path we both kept quiet, admiring what we had missed, what we helped build all those years ago, what would soon be gone unless we fixed it, keeping it in its cleanest and finest form, using it as it once was but we both knew we couldn't do so, so that's why we are here, selling this land is the best option, and we needed to get everything out of that cabin that we wanted to keep his memory alive, to be able to show the kids the man that helped us, so we can be the same if not better man to them and someday their kids. Getting closer to the cabin

light shined through the trees highlighting the path and at the end of the trail casting light on the cabin and only the cabin, as if to show us where to go, standing there only tears could start to form, the man we loved and the land he taught us on, is and would be gone, but we can keep his memory alive, in ourselves and from that which we would find in the cabin. In an almost simultaneous step, we went closer, reached the door and opened it.

The Cabin

In an almost simultaneous step, we went closer, reached the door and opened it. The light from the sun shining in, the dust in the air greeting us, the smell of old wood and undisturbed dust filled the air, yet we could still smell grandad's cologne, the cooking that grandma had made, not walking into the cabin just staring, speechless, we stared for what seemed to be an eternity, finally breaking out of the frozen state we walked in, the boards creaked and more dust shot up, causing me to sneeze, wiping my nose on my sleeve, getting to the kitchen still smelling as the spices that were never opened after grandma's death, walking to the guest bedroom, it all seemed to be frozen in time, undisturbed, everything as I remember it, the master bedroom seemed to show the final moments, the bed still unmade, the towels still on

the floor from what could have been a shower or leak, claiming the bead as if were still kids I screamed "Dibs" and Charles looked shocked but still impressed that I managed to get it in before him, "Fine, I'll take the guest bedroom", throwing my stuff on the bed, just as the other room when disturbed the dust shot up, being seen in the ray of sun beaming through the window, walking back to room where I lost my hearing the memories flooded back, the sound rang through my head, feeling the sound of nothing come back, I stood frozen, vividly being able to see my dad kneel beside me, seeing gradad throw the airhorn, all being a vivid image, seeing it as if it were happening again right in front of me. Chales approached from behind, I did not hear him, only coming back when he grabbed my shoulders and

shook me, snapping back, I looked at him and looked around for anything that might be of value to keep, spotting something of value once Charles moved in that direction, Saw it the same airhorn as from all those years ago, without a second thought I swooped it from Charles, held it in my hand and stared, stared at it, started at Charles, swapping between the two, cracking a smile, holding it up, shaking it, the marble inside still clinking against the inside of the canister, asking him in a mocking tone, "Want to see who can last longer?" I started cracking up, handing it back and saying "You should keep it, to remind you of what you did to your younger brother" in a mocking baby voice, practically rolling on the floor, making it creak louder than 2 old people getting frisky in bed. Charles seemed unamused, but after a few

seconds he finally joined in with a small cackle that turned into a full in comedic laugh, as if he heard the best joke ever , forcing him to bend over and gasp for air. After a time unknown to me I gathered myself, stood up and dusted myself off, continuing to search through all that is in the room, looking through boxes finding old memorabilia, medals, badges from his time on the police force and so on, until moving one box aside, seeing the crack in the wall, tried to open it but it stuck, calling over “check this out”, he came over, looked intrigued “you think its a door?”, “dunno”, trying to open it we remained unsuccessful, “must be a normal sign of aging”, I agreed and we moved on, but something about it, the way it looked, the cracks in the wood, the slit that was there that made it seem as if someone shimmied it open, it seemed to only bother me but

nevertheless we left the room and searched through the rest. Finding all sorts of strange things, things we don't recognize, old songs still on CD's, on VHS's, shell casings, all that would point to an old police man and old person, well thinking back, it could also show a collector but nevertheless we went through it all, every cabinet, every box, every drawer, if it could open we looked through it. Finding his old journal made us reminisce, the sound of the old pages being unstuck, the smell of old paper with the occasional cigarette burns, turning the pages, the writing seemed unreadable unless you focused all of your knowledge and then it seemed as if he was crazy. The notes describe something called "The Ember King", the page smothered in burn marks, streaks of ash, all indications that this was a page of importance.

Reading further in the book, every page beyond the 4th page had some mention of “The Ember King”, with burn patterns, ash streaks and a strange symbol that I only later would see, but by then I would wish we never went. Reading further the shift in what was written, the change in handwriting, the date read that fateful day that I lost my hearing, simply reading “The grandkids came to visit, Rose made her famous Sunday roast, but the kids dad is getting less patient as to finding out what I have been doing in the basement, the basement no one knows about except their dad.”, “Charles, Get over here!” Charles came walking over, covered in dust, wiping his hands, “What is it?”, “Check this out”, “Where do you think the basement is?”, “Dunno, but we can look. See if we find anything that does

not belong or looks to be a door.”, we proceeded to look through the entire house, not finding any indication of where it could be, feeling defeated, we made plans to drive the distance to the nearest town, 20 some km away to get food. Walking out of the cabin the floorboards on the deck creaked when weight was applied, the door squeaked as it was being closed, the click of the doors lock when the key was turned, on the walk to the car the acorns and leaves crunched under our weight, the sounds of birds singing, the animals further in the distance out of eyesight but close enough to hear them, the car being spotted further in the distance, Charles broke the silence “You think once we are back we go look closer at every floor board and wall to find the basement?”, “Hell yeah!”, I replied, wanting to know what was kept or being done in

there. Only starting to talk again after the car's alarm goes off, to indicate that the lock has been triggered and is able to open, opening the door simultaneously the click echoes through the dense forest. Getting in and starting the car, putting it in reverse driving off, you could hear the gravel spin out from beneath the tires, the drive was long, the winding roads, few to no cars on the road, radio constantly going out of tune, swapping to random frequencies. Shutting it off, sitting in silence, only the sound of the wheels gliding over the smooth road, "Road has to be freshly done" Charles said, he was one to pick up small details, "You think." I said knowing that an explanation would come yet it never did. Driving into the town, "Joyville, Vance, population 12000" I read aloud, driving in we saw the life the town had to offer, small cafes with lights

hanging above the tables, bigger restaurants with the normal light on the inside, rubbery seats and wooden tables that were definitely “cleaned” after the last costumer. We picked a small cafe “Jakes coffee and donuts”, taking a seat inside nearest the window, looking out on the road, “Good day gentlemen, I am Josh, I will be your server today, do you already know what you will be having or should I give you gents some time and come back”, “We'll both have a single espresso, black, and a box of assorted health donuts”, “all right, I'll be right out with your order”. Charles knew what to get before I opened my menu, but I had to give it to him. He ain't wrong as to what the order would have been. Waiting in silence, hearing the brew of coffee, plates being shifted, forks and knives starching,clinking, the waiter approaches our table

with our coffee and box of donuts. The coffee still steaming hot, burns my tongue as I swallow it, opening the box of donuts, a divine smell immediately hit our noses, those donuts did not stand any chance of lasting, eating them as if we were malnourished, once all was eaten barley leaving crumbs Charles put his hand into his jacket, pulling out the notebook, placing it on the table, not a word was spoken, only speaking when asked if we wanted a refill on our coffee. "James, I think we should read all of it,maybe we can find the door easier or at least understand what grandpa was thinking or going through.", I had no complaint, no reason to say no, wanting to know where the door was, was also part of the mystery, moving my head whispering "Okay", we opened it and started reading, after what had to have been 2 hours of

coffee drinking and more donuts reading, "The same symbol, the same thing named, it gives no context as how to do anything, or what any of this means.", "Yep" I slowly say under my breath, sitting back, taking another donut to eat and a swig of my coffee. Calling our waiter over , "2 boxes of the donuts and the bill, please.", "We should head back, Charles, get some sleep maybe that will help.", Charles already packed up, "Ok", paying the bill, standing and walking to the car with donuts that would have to last the final 2 days we were spending at the cabin. The drive back was long, hiding beneath the open sky of stars, no cars passing us by on the road, we sat in silence on the radio playing, jumping just as it had before between every possible frequency eventually settling on 34.5 idp, an unknown song start to play,

every word taking us closer to going into a trance, only snapping out of it when Charles swerved to avoid hitting a deer that froze in the middle of the road. The tires came to a screeching halt, for a few moments we sat looking onto the road in front of us, the deer bolting into the woods to the left, turning off the radio, getting out to see if there was any damage, despite knowing we knew he did not hit anything, all seemed normal around the car until, while walking behind Charles I bumped into him, "What's wrong?" I asked, he did not utter a word, lifting only his pointer finger to point at it, the symbol, the same symbol that's in grandad's notebook, carved right above the left blinker. Looking at the symbol, standing in silence, only the distant hoot of an owl can be heard. "Wha.." I managed to mumble under my breath, silence,

without a word being said we got into the car and drove back to the cabin, parking, getting out and walking to the cabin, everything seemed to shift in a manner that said “everything will go to hell”. Once inside the cabin, still stuck in a shocked state, Charles threw the book onto the small coffee table, sending dust into the air that could be seen in the ray of moonlight. “Night” Charles said, already walking to his room, shutting the door behind him, I stayed awake and kept reading. Over and over the same words repeated themselves: The Ember King — scrawled in different sizes, sometimes neat and deliberate, other times like the last frantic scribbles of a dying man. But nothing else. No explanations, no descriptions, no instructions. It was like staring into fog — shapes shifting, almost forming into something clear, but

never giving me anything solid to hold onto. I flipped back through the pages, searching for some kind of pattern. Dates, codes, initials — anything. But the handwriting grew more erratic with each entry. Some of the pages weren't even written anymore, just black smears, as though he had tried to burn the words off the page after writing them. Leaning back, I rubbed my eyes, exhaustion setting into my bones. My ears rang faintly with the endless static hum of the new aids. Every so often, I swore I caught the sound of crackling fire beneath it, but when I tugged them out, there was nothing. Silence. "Nothing," I muttered under my breath, my voice sounding foreign even to myself. "Absolutely nothing." The cabin gave nothing back, only the slow groan of the old wood in the wind. I glanced at Charles'

closed door. He had fallen asleep hours ago, and I envied him. My mind wouldn't stop racing. Finally, I closed the journal and set it aside. All I had now were questions. Who—or what—was the Ember King? Why had Grandpa filled every page of his journal with it? And why leave no answers, no warnings — only madness on paper? The moonlight shifted further across the floorboards, the beam narrowing as the night deepened. My eyes felt heavy. The sound of my own breathing, the faint hum of the aids, and the creak of the chair beneath me blended into one dull haze. I told myself I'd look again in the morning, maybe with a clearer head. For now, there was no point clawing at shadows. Dragging myself up, I carried the journal to the coffee table, laying it down gently as though it were fragile. My reflection caught in the

black windowpane — pale, worn, eyes sunken from reading too long. Behind me, the cabin stretched into darkness, silent and waiting. I didn't bother looking at Charles' door again. I knew he wouldn't wake. With a final glance at the journal, its cover dull in the pale light, I whispered, "We'll try again tomorrow." And with that, I left the room, the sound of the door to my own bedroom clicking shut behind me. The morning light crept in thin and pale through the blinds, but it did nothing to lift the weight pressing down on me. My head felt fogged, my body sluggish. From the look on Charles' face when he stepped out of his room, I knew he hadn't slept either. We didn't say it aloud, but the truth hung between us like smoke: neither of us had gotten any real rest. Every time my eyes shut, I saw him — Grandpa — standing at the edge of the

cabin, his figure swallowed in shadows, eyes glowing faint like dying coals. He never moved. He just stood there, watching. Silent. "Maybe..." Charles started, his voice dry and cracked from the night, "...we should cut this trip short." I wanted to argue. I wanted to say we hadn't even searched the cabin properly. But the fight wasn't in me. My chest felt hollow, my thoughts unfocused. All I managed was a nod. The drive back felt longer than the drive there. The forest seemed darker, the trees leaning in close, almost conspiratorial. The radio spat static half the way, and even when music did come through, neither of us sang along. We just sat there, eyes forward, lost in silence. Every now and then I caught Charles glancing at me, like he wanted to speak. Each time, he swallowed it back down. I did the same. Neither of

us wanted to admit the same thing: we'd both spent the night with the same nightmares. By the time we pulled through the gates of his estate, the sun was already high, its warmth doing little to thaw the cold unease stuck in my chest.

Inside his mansion, Charles put on a pot of coffee. We sat at his long marble counter, steam rising between us. He cradled his mug like it was the only thing keeping him steady. "We didn't find anything," he said finally, breaking the silence. His tone was heavy, like the words had been dragged out of him. "Just madness on paper," I muttered. He nodded, not meeting my eyes. For a long while, we just drank, letting the bitter taste keep us anchored. Eventually, Charles leaned back, sighing deep, and muttered, "Maybe some things are better left

alone.” I didn’t argue. I couldn’t. By late afternoon, I stood, thanked him for the coffee, and grabbed my bag. Charles walked me to the door but didn’t follow me out. He only stood there in the doorway, hands shoved deep in his pockets, staring past me at nothing. The drive home was uneventful. Suburbs replaced the countryside, and soon I was pulling into my driveway, the familiar sight of my kids’ toys scattered across the lawn grounding me in a way I desperately needed. Inside, my wife greeted me with her usual smile, the kids clattering around, their noise filling the air. I let it wash over me, grounding me further. For a moment, I could almost forget the cabin, the journal, the symbol. Almost. The evening passed in a blur — dinner, chores, the boys demanding I help them fix their pillow fort. I played along, let myself laugh, forced

myself to blend back into the life I knew. But when night fell and I lay in bed, staring at the ceiling, my body finally gave out. My eyelids dropped heavy, my breathing slowed, and I felt myself sinking deep into sleep. The dream began where the day had ended — in my own house. I stood in the living room, the soft glow of the lamp spilling across the carpet. At first it seemed normal, but then I noticed the silence. No hum from the fridge, no ticking clock, no distant cars outside. Just silence. Then, a faint glow in the corner of the room. Like embers, burning faintly in the dark. As my eyes adjusted, I saw it. A figure — tall, impossibly tall, its head nearly brushing the ceiling. Its body was all shadow and smoke, but from within, veins of fire pulsed faintly, glowing through cracks in blackened skin like molten rock. The heat radiating from it

made the air shimmer. Its face was little more than a skull of charred wood and ash, two hollow sockets burning with faint, flickering coals. It didn't move toward me. It didn't speak. It only stood there, tilting its head as if studying me. And then, slowly, its mouth opened. No words came out, only the sound of fire — the low, endless crackle of wood burning. The heat swelled, choking, suffocating. I wanted to run, to scream, but my body wouldn't obey. All I could do was stand there as the figure leaned closer, the embers in its eyes flaring brighter— I gasped awake. My chest heaved, sweat soaked the sheets, and the room was dark again. Normal. But the heat lingered.

Grandads

Journal

Grandfather's Journal

Entry 1 — March 12, 1988

It was a mild day. Rose spent the morning baking bread, and the cabin still carries the smell of it. She hummed that tune of hers while she worked — the one I never can place but always recognize.

I spent most of the afternoon repairing the porch steps. The wood has grown soft with the damp, and it won't last another winter if I don't keep after it. My hands ache now, but that's nothing new.

On my walk this evening, I came across something strange. Deeper in the pines, where the ground stays wet, there was a patch of embers glowing red. No firewood, no ashes, only the embers themselves, like coals pulled straight from a stove. They did not dim, not even as the rain started to fall.

I stood there too long staring at them. At times, I thought I heard a faint hiss, almost a whisper in the crackle, but Rose called me in for supper before I could think much of it.

It was probably nothing. Still, I cannot shake it from my mind.

Entry 2 — June 5, 1988

Strange again today. I went back to the grove. The embers were still there, glowing as before, though weeks have passed.

I knelt close. The heat licked at my face, but there was no smoke. I dropped a twig onto them, and the embers devoured it without flame.

I thought I heard a low murmur in the crackle. Not words, exactly, but a shape of sound that raised the hair

on my arms. I don't tell Rose these things. She would only worry.

Instead, I told her I had been burning brush. She frowned but said nothing.

When I smoked my pipe near the embers, the glow sharpened. I could almost sense a presence watching from the darkness. A hunger. And in that hunger, a name pressed itself into my mind: The Ember King.

Entry 3 — September 2, 1989

Rose is gone.

The words still don't feel real. The cabin is silent now without her humming, her footsteps, her scolding when I left my boots by the door.

I went back to the embers tonight. I don't know why.
Maybe because the silence at home was too much.

When I smoked, the fire grew brighter. For the briefest
moment, I thought I heard her voice in the crackle. Soft.
Faint. Just my name.

But there was something else beneath it. A darker
thread curling through the warmth, like a second voice
behind hers.

I think... he listened. The Ember King.

Entry 4 — December 21, 1989

The fire wants more. It makes me hungry.

Tobacco keeps it bright, but I have tried other offerings
— wine, bread, even the small carvings I used to

whittle. Each time, the glow flares then dies down.
Never enough.

Tonight it spoke. Not Rose's voice this time. It was lower, harsher. I could almost make out the words: "Hunger. Ash."

The boys visited last week. The accident still troubles me. James with ringing ears, Jake worse. But after, the fire dimmed. I slept.

Did it take from them what it demanded from me? Was that the price?

The Ember King is no guardian. He is hungry and wearing fire.

[Several pages have been torn out. The next surviving entry is months later.]

Entry 5 — April 10, 1990

The King. That is what I call it now — The Ember King.

The cabin groans at night. I hear the walls breathe. Sometimes, when I wake in the dark, there is a glow under the floorboards, pulsing like a heart.

I smoke every night to keep him quiet. The smoke buys silence. Without it, he stirs, and I can feel his eyes in the dark.

I asked for Rose again, begging for her voice. I would give anything to hear her hum just once more.

The fire answered with silence. Then laughter.

Entry 6 — November 1, 1990

I can hardly hold the pen. My hands shake with ash.

The words I write are not mine anymore.

Don't let the fire speak.

Don't let the fire speak.

Don't let the fire speak.

The symbol appears everywhere. I scratch it without meaning to. Into the wood. Into my own skin.

If I keep smoking, he stays quiet. If I stop, he whispers.
And if he whispers, he will speak.

I cannot let him speak. The Ember King must be kept at bay.

Entry 7 — [Undated, final page]

The shadows move outside the cabin. They wait. They whisper. "Smoke. Smoke. Smoke."

I hear Rose's voice calling from the flames, but I know it is not her. I know it is him now. The Ember King.

If the fire is silent, we are safe.

If the fire speaks, he will come through.

[The bottom of the page is scorched. The symbol has been burned deep into the paper, the edges black and brittle. The next several pages are missing entirely.]

The Weight of
His Words

I closed the journal, though the words still burned behind my eyes. The leather cover felt heavier in my hands now, as if the madness it contained had seeped into the paper itself. Every line I had read carried weight — not just of ink and grief, but of something older, darker. I could almost hear his voice in the scrawl, whispering through the smudges, through the torn pages, through the scorch marks that refused to die even after decades. For a long while, I just sat there at the kitchen table, staring at the cover. The hum of the refrigerator, the faint tick of the clock on the wall — all of it seemed muffled, as though the world had dimmed around me. It occurred to

me how quiet it was, how different from the cabin's relentless creaks and groans, its whispering shadows. When Charles came into the room, he said nothing. His eyes drifted to the journal, and I saw the same heaviness mirrored in him. He poured himself a coffee, his movements stiff, and sat across from me. The steam rose between us like smoke, curling and vanishing before it reached the ceiling. The Ordinary was becoming laden with the Unnatural. "Do you think it's real?" Charles finally asked, breaking the silence. His voice was low and strained, like he was afraid of what answer he would find. I wanted to tell him it was nonsense. The ramblings of a man who

lost his wife and drank too much in the woods. But the words caught in my throat. I could still see the final page scorched black, the symbols carved deep, the repeated warning: Don't let the fire speak. "I don't know," I admitted, my voice barely above a whisper. "But he believed it. And now... I'm not so sure it's just madness."

The silence that followed was heavy. We both wanted to close the subject, to forget the journal and whatever sanity it once promised. Neither of us could.

"Maybe some things are better left alone," Charles finally murmured, his gaze distant and

clouded. He sipped his coffee, but the tension in his shoulders remained, a coiled spring ready to snap. "I keep thinking about what he went through," I said, leaning on the table, feeling the cool marble under my palms. "How easily it can take hold. It makes me wonder... how much of it is real?"

He shifted in his seat. "It doesn't matter if it's real, Jake. What matters is that he thought it was real. And that... that can change everything." His words sank in, heavy and foreboding. I thought back to the journal entries, the fire that wouldn't die, the whispers that crawled beneath the surface. If it could wrap around my grandfather's mind, how close

was I to being caught in the same web? The mood remained thick as I finished my coffee, my thoughts racing with dread. “We should go back,” I said suddenly. “To the cabin. There has to be something we missed.” Charles’s expression hardened, shadows flickering across his features. “No. We can’t.” “But what if there’s a way to understand it? If we can decode what he left behind, maybe... maybe we can protect ourselves.” His knuckles turned white as he gripped the mug. “Jake. I’m telling you — we need to let it go. It’s not worth it.” But I could see the doubt in his eyes, the nagging fear that mirrored my own. The longer

we sat there, the more the gravity of those words twisted around us.

By late afternoon, the weight of it all became too much. I gathered my bag and stood, thanking Charles for the coffee, though it felt hollow now. He walked me to the door but didn't follow me out. He stayed in the frame, hands deep in his pockets, staring past me at nothing. The drive home was long, though the miles weren't many. Suburbs replaced the countryside, and the sight of my kids' toys scattered across the lawn should have lifted the fog. It didn't. Inside, my wife smiled, the boys clattered about, and the house filled with

the kind of noise that usually grounded me. I let it wash over me, forced myself to play along, to laugh at their antics, to fix their collapsing pillow fort.

But under it all, a quiet dread gnawed at me. Every time I blinked, I saw embers pulsing in the dark, waiting. That night, when the house had gone still, I lay in bed staring at the ceiling. My wife's soft breathing beside me should have been comforting. It wasn't. The journal's words pressed into my skull, heavy and inescapable. How had he penned those last grim notes? What had lost its meaning in the blackened pages? If the fire is silent, we are safe. If the fire speaks, he will come through.

Sleep claimed me slowly, dragging me down despite my fight. As the dark closed in, I swore I could hear it again — a faint crackle beneath the silence, like embers shifting, waiting to speak.

Cinders at the

Threshold

The dream began in silence.

I stood in the hallway of my own home, though something about it was wrong. The light was dimmer, stretched thin like it was fighting to stay alive. The photographs on the wall — my wife, the boys — were blurred, their faces smudged as though the glass had fogged over. At the end of the hall, the front door stood ajar. A faint glow pulsed in the gap, steady and unnatural, like coals banked in a hearth. My feet moved without my say. Each step carried me closer to that glow, closer to the crackle I could just barely hear beneath the silence. It wasn't the warm crackle of a

fireplace. It was lower, deeper, like wood rotting as it burned. I paused only once, halfway down the hall. My skin prickled with heat, though the air around me stayed cold. The glow sharpened, and I thought I saw shapes shifting just beyond the threshold. Tall. Lean. Watching. My body wanted to turn back, to close my eyes and wake. But my hand lifted instead, reaching for the doorknob. And then I heard it — a voice that wasn't a voice, a hiss wrapped in fire.

“Smoke.”

The word crawled through the crack in the door like ash caught in a draft.

I staggered back, heart hammering, but my eyes wouldn't leave the glow. The cinders burned brighter, pulsing in rhythm with my own breath. "Smoke." Louder this time. Hungrier. Something moved in the dark beyond the door, a figure shifting in the ember light. The threshold quaked with heat, the wood blackening, the knob glowing faint red. I knew then what he meant in the journal. If the fire is silent, we are safe. If the fire speaks... The voice hissed again, low and endless, pressing through the door.

“Let me in.”

Involuntarily, I reached for the handle. But as my fingers brushed the warm surface, a flash of clarity washed over me. With a surge of will, I pulled my hand back. No. I couldn't let him in — whatever it was that beckoned beyond the threshold. The crackling grew frantic, a chorus of whispers surrounding me as the shadows twisted and contorted against the light. My heart raced while I fought to reclaim control of my breath, wrestling against the primal urge to submit. Suddenly, I was yanked from the hallucination, the imagined hallway collapsing around me. My eyes flew open, flinging me

back into the dark confines of my bedroom. The warm absence washed over me like a tidal wave, flooding the space with the faint smell of smoke. I sat upright, gasping as if I had just resurfaced from deep water. The weight of the heavy dark pressed against my chest, and for a moment, I was disoriented — was it still night? Had I left the door open? The clock on the wall ticked relentlessly, emphasizing the silence that filled the room, but it was punctuated by the echo of my dream. I strained to listen beyond the thrum of the clock, but all I heard was the gentle breathing of my wife next to me. Yet, the air felt charged, alive with anticipation. I swung

my legs over the side of the bed, the wood cold beneath my feet. My heart still raced as I moved into the hallway, drawn inexplicably back toward the front door, the memory of that eerie glow still vivid in my mind. I reached out, hand hovering near the door handle, but I froze. The fire isn't supposed to speak. With trembling fingers, I gripped the handle and slowly pulled the door open. The hallway lay before me, bathed in the faint moonlight filtering through the window at the far end. Everything appeared ordinary, the shadows simply cast by familiar furniture. But I felt an undercurrent of unease, a dark reminder of what I had just fled within my mind. I made my

way cautiously down the hall, each step echoing in the stillness. I peered into the living room, where the glow of a dying ember flickered in the stone fireplace. I'd let the fire go out before bed, but now it pulsed softly as if fed by unseen hands. I approached the hearth, drawn in against my better judgment. The remnants of the fire danced defiantly in the dark, casting ominous shadows across the floor. As I knelt before the fireplace, I was struck by a scent that curled around me — not just smoke, but something earthy and rotten, as though the ashes held memories of what had burned before. I rubbed my temples, fighting against the encroaching panic. Am I

losing my mind? I don't know how long I knelt there, staring into the embers, feeling their heat radiate against my skin. Each flicker drew forth the image of the figure I saw in my dream, both terrifying and oddly inviting. "Smoke," I echoed, my voice trembling in the night air.

I shook my head, forcing myself to stand. I couldn't afford to linger. I turned to leave, but as I did, a rustling caught my ear, a soft sound threading through the familiar hum of my home. I froze. For an instant, I thought I saw a shadow dart past the corner of my vision—a quick, dark movement, fleeting. Panic clawed

at my throat, and I turned back, glancing around the room. “Hello?”. My voice was drowned in silence. I took a step back, ready to retreat to the safety of my bedroom when something shifted near the window. The curtains billowed slightly, undulating in an invisible breeze that shouldn’t have existed in this stillness. A stronger gust of foreboding chilled me to the bone. I poked my head closer to the window, squinting into the darkness outside. The trees stood silent and still, their branches clawing at the sky, but I felt it — a growing awareness, as though something was waiting just beyond the light. I edged closer to the window, heart pounding against my ribs.

Shadows swayed outside, and beneath them, I locked eyes with the light flickering back at me from the old gnarled tree at the edge of the yard. In that moment, I felt it again — warmth creeping up from beneath the threshold, a vibration of desire that teased at my instincts. The ember's call whispered in my ear.

“Let me in.”

I stumbled back, fear washing over me like ice water. I staggered to my feet, retreating from the window as dread wormed its way into my mind. I could still hear them, the whispers gathering volume, melding with the crackling

of the dying fire. "Smoke..." they murmured, woven through the dark. "Smoke..." The repetition quickened my heartbeat, and as I turned to escape, I felt the weight of the shadows closing in. I had to get away. I had to shut it all out.

I turned back down the hall, fleeing the gathering despair, urgency propelling me toward the safety of the bedroom. I collapsed onto the bed, pulling the covers over my head, trying to block out the world. But I knew better than to think I was safe. The fire was still speaking, and its hunger had only begun to stir.

Whispers in the

Shadows

The morning light filtered through the curtains, painting the room in muted shades of gold. Yet, instead of warmth, it felt like a thin veil over a lingering coldness, a reminder of the insistent dread that gripped me through the night.

I sat up slowly, the sense of heaviness still entwined around my chest. The remnants of my dream clung to the edges of my mind like smoke, blurring the line between sleep and waking. I let out a shaky breath, willing myself to shake the remnants of my nightmares. Downstairs, the clatter of breakfast preparations filled the house, familiar and comforting, but it couldn't erase the chaos that

gnawed at me. Those warnings from Grandpa's journal echoed aloud — the threats buried in ash and coal that seemed more tangible with each passing moment. I walked into the kitchen where the smell of eggs and toast wafted through the air. My wife turned, her face lighting up with a smile that faltered the moment she saw my expression. "Jake, are you alright?" she asked, concerned about lacing her voice. I forced a smile, trying to convince her — and myself — that everything was okay. "Just a rough night, I guess."

She nodded, but her eyes searched mine, clearly not buying the act. I couldn't blame her; I felt like I was carrying the weight of the world.

I poured myself a cup of coffee, savoring the bitter edge as I tried to ground myself in the present. The boys came barreling into the kitchen, their laughter brightening the space—a stark contrast to the shadows that loomed in my mind. They demanded my attention, pulling me back into the normalcy of family life. But as much as I wanted to be present with them, my thoughts kept drifting back to the cabin and the words I had read.

I glanced at the clock, its ticking now feeling like a countdown rather than a gentle reminder of time passing. I needed to talk to Charles. We hadn't finished our conversation about the

journal, and I was beginning to realize that the old man's warnings wouldn't fade by themselves. After breakfast, I stole a moment alone in my study, pulling out my phone and texting Charles. *We need to talk. Soon. I'm starting to think we've only just scratched the surface.* I stared at the screen, anxiously awaiting his reply. While I waited, my thoughts drummed against the edges of my resolve. There was something darker looming, an unnameable threat that clung to the very air around me. The boys noticed me lingering, the silence stretching uncomfortably between us. "Dad? Are you coming to play?" my youngest asked, his big eyes shining with hope. "Yeah,

Dad!” his brother chimed in. “We built the biggest pillow fort ever!” I felt a surge of guilt wash over me as I looked at their eager faces. But could I shake off the unease that had settled deep within? “Of course, I’m coming,” I said, pushing thoughts of the Ember King away for now. I followed them into the living room, joining their raucous laughter as they showed me the fortress they had created. But even as I laughed and played along, part of me remained detached, a spectator in my own life. I wasn’t really there — my mind raced with visions of the glowing ember at the cabin and the chilling warning of the journal.

The afternoon slipped by, but the weight grew heavier with each hour that passed. The very walls of my home began to feel oppressive, as if they bore witness to my thoughts, the evening shadows lengthening unnaturally with the fading light. As I tucked the boys into bed later that night, I read to them, my voice steady despite the turmoil brewing inside me. But as their eyes fluttered closed, I found that I couldn't hold it back any longer. "Boys, if you ever hear a voice, or see something strange, you promise to come get me, okay?" I asked, my tone more serious than I intended. They both exchanged puzzled glances. "Why?" my eldest asked. "Just... promise me," I repeated

gently, needing to hear them acknowledge my fear. "Okay, Dad. We promise," they said in unison, and I tucked them in tightly, leaning down to press a kiss to their foreheads. Long after I closed the door, I remained rooted in the hallway, the weight of their promise pressing down on me. I could feel the walls of the house closing in, shadows pooling in the corners that stretched toward me like fingers. The calmness of the house felt deceptive. I returned to my bedroom, where the atmosphere was thick with the same dread I had sensed before. I tried to rationalize it, but every creak of the floorboards and whisper of the wind raked my nerves raw. As I lay there,

eyes fixed on the ceiling, I heard it again — a faint crackling sound, almost like the rustling of paper or the whisper of ash in a gentle breeze. I sat up, heart racing. The sound was too close, too familiar. My mind fled back to the journal and the horrors it contained. Unable to shake the sense of impending doom, I pushed myself out of bed. The house was still, but I felt the pull; I needed to confront whatever was lurking just out of sight. I moved toward the living room, cautiously making my way through the dim light. Every shadow seemed to dance, taunting me, and I could almost hear them whispering, teasing the edges of my sanity. As I entered the living room, I paused. The

fireplace sat cold. From somewhere deep within the stones, I swore I heard a faint hiss — a low, hungry sound lurking just beneath the surface. “Smoke,” it seemed to say, echoing the words I had read. The air grew thick, swirling with a tension I couldn’t ignore. I stepped closer, drawn to the mouth of the unused fireplace, staring into the dark void as if waiting for something to emerge. The shadows undulated, and I felt the overwhelming urge to retreat, but instead, I held my ground. I wouldn’t be ruled by fear. And then, unexpectedly, the warmth flared brightly from the depths, cinders glowing in the darkness like two embers in the dead of night,

beckoning. I took a shaky breath and felt the weight of my grandfather's warnings crash over me like a wave. If the fire speaks, he will come through. The air constricted around me, charged with an energy that felt dangerously alive. I turned and bolted for the door, ready to flee, but was stopped in my tracks as I felt something shift behind me. I closed my eyes tightly, willing myself to wake from this nightmare, but when I opened them again, the shadows had thickened, swirling in the corners, waiting. And I realized then — whatever was with me wasn't going to let me go so easily.

The Ritual

The sun hung low in the sky, casting long shadows that crept across the yard. I stood at the kitchen table, staring blankly at a map spread open before me, tracing the winding paths that led back to the cabin with my finger. Charles had agreed to meet me here, but my heart felt heavy. I needed answers, but the idea of returning filled me with dread. The journal lay near my elbow, its leather cover marred with signs of wear, a reminder of the dark legacy we were encountering. I couldn't shake the chilling weight of my grandfather's warnings, the words echoing like a chant in my head: *"Don't let the fire speak."* When Charles entered, he wore a look of resignation,

as if he too sensed the inevitability of what lay ahead. “You really think we should go back there?” he asked, his voice heavy with apprehension. “I don’t know,” I admitted, letting out a breath I hadn’t realized I was holding. “But we need to find out more. We can’t just ignore what he wrote.” Charles’s shoulders slumped as he glanced over the map. “If we do this, we have to be prepared. We don’t understand what we’re dealing with. Last time...” he trailed off, his voice thick with the memories of what had happened at the cabin. Last time. The phrase hung in the air, heavy with unspoken fears. It was when we had unearthed shadows from our past, faced our

grandfather's madness, and uncovered the terrifying truth of The Ember King. As we prepared for the trip, the unease weighed heavily in the air. I tried to focus on practical matters: packing flashlights, extra batteries, and the supplies we would need. My fingers trembled slightly as I closed the bag, a stark reminder of the darkness that awaited us. The drive to the cabin was tense, silence stretching uncomfortably between us. The once-familiar route now felt like a descent into some abyss. With every mile that passed, I could feel the weight of memories pressing in, the ghost of our grandfather's presence lingering like smoke. As we neared the cabin, the forest

thickened, shadows twisting into grotesque shapes. The trees loomed over the road, their gnarled branches reaching out like skeletal fingers. I glanced at Charles; the tension in his jaw was unmistakable. I shared his apprehension, my heart hammering as if it understood the danger that lay ahead. Pulling into the clearing, the cabin stood there, sentinel-like against the encroaching night. I felt a wave of nausea rush over me — the memories of my last visit surged forth, flooding my thoughts with visions of the journal and the unsettling realization of what we were truly facing. As we stepped out of the car, the air felt heavy with the aftertaste of ash. It was the

first time I truly noticed how the remnants of that place clung to the ground, a sense of something watching us from the underbrush. I shivered, fighting the urge to flee. "We should check the basement first," I said, half-trying to convince myself that facing my fears was the only way to move forward. Charles hesitated but nodded, determination flickering in his eyes. Navigating through the familiar yet now sinister entrance, the darkened rooms felt crowded with echoes of the past. The air grew heavier, the lingering scent of smoke almost suffocating. In the master bedroom, we lifted the warped floorboards, revealing the entrance to the basement. As we descended into the

darkness, a sense of dread pooled in my gut. I turned on the flashlight, illuminating a space filled with clutter and debris. Shadows danced across the walls, making the room feel almost alive.

“Look,” Charles said, shining his light on an old crate covered in dust. “What do you think is in there?” I walked over, kneeling to inspect it closely. The faded markings read like some forgotten language. A chill ran down my spine. “Could be anything,” I murmured. “Let’s see if we can find anything that might give us more clues about... well, everything.” As we rummaged through the crate, our unease grew. Each item revealed deep echoes of our

grandfather's past — charred fragments of wood, trinkets that felt ominous, and a few crumpled pieces of paper, their content fading with age. “Here,” I said, pulling out a half-burnt journal page. The frantic scrawl was unmistakable. “It’s a part of his notes.” Charles leaned in, his flashlight flickering over the words. *The King demands offerings... smoke must flow into the night...* “James’s accident... I wrote down every word. But he took them. The price was paid,” it continued. Turning the page, I could see erratic writing washing over itself, desperate and scared. My pulse quickened as I read the scrawl: *“Do not let the fire speak.”* “It’s all connected,” I breathed,

overwhelmed. “He thought there was a way to control it, and now...” The air grew dense, as if every shadow crowded closer, drawing energy from our fear. “Jake,” Charles said, his voice urgent as he pulled his flashlight toward the corners of the room. “Do you feel that?”

A whisper curled through the air around us, almost imperceptible. It sent chills racing along my spine. Beneath the whispers, a low crackling began to emerge, echoing the warning of the journal. Then it hit me — the warmth I hadn’t noticed until now. The unmistakable sense that something was

stirring in the shadows, a presence gathering force, eager to breach the darkness.

“It’s here,” I hissed, backing against the wall, my heart pounding with panic.

“Get ready,” Charles said, his bravado faltering. “We might have to run.”

The shadows shifted and stretched, coiling in darker corners as if they had substance, a mind of their own. I fought the urge to scream, fighting against the sensations that spiraled within me. Charles spun toward the door as the sound crescendoed to a roar. “We need to get out!” Before we could move, the air thickened, and a voice broke through the

cacophony—a sound like embers igniting in the hearth, low and guttural.

“Let me in.”

I recognized it immediately, the thread of an ancient power underlying his tone. As fear propelled us forward, we turned to escape. But just as I reached for the stairway, the door slammed shut, the sound echoing like thunder. The walls trembled around us, alive with the sound of crackling fire.

Charles and I stared at each other, the realization dawning: we had awakened

The Ember King.

The

Confrontation

The air felt thicker as the door slammed shut behind us, trapping us in the dim light of the basement. The shadows deepened, curling like fingers around us as I turned to face Charles. His eyes were wide, mirroring my fear, but beneath the surface lay a flicker of determination. "She wouldn't want us to—" he began, but the rest of his words died in his throat as a low rumble echoed through the walls, vibrating beneath our feet. I could almost feel the cabin pulse with life; it thrummed with an energy that was both ancient and furious. "We need to find a way out," I said, my voice nearly lost in the low, crackling sound. "We shouldn't be here." But

the air seemed to vibrate with a different kind of resonance, drawing my attention to the symbol etched into the wooden beams. I moved closer, heart racing. “Look,” I said, pointing to the intricate design. “It’s the same as the one in the journal.” Charles joined me, peering closely at the mark. “What does it mean?” “I don’t know,” I admitted, guilt clawing at my throat. The journal held some answers, but they felt more like riddles now, twisted and buried in Grandpa's madness. “But it has to mean something. It has to help us figure out how to—” Suddenly, the faint ember light flickered in my mind, a memory from the journal surging back. The words were

unmistakable: *The King wants more. Blood
for flame. Fire for silence.*

A chill dropped through me as the implications
settled in. I turned toward the stairs, the sense
of urgency swelling within me. “We can’t wait.
We need to get out.” But as I stepped back
toward the staircase, a sound stopped me
cold—a whisper, curled around the corners of
my consciousness like smoke weaving
through the air.

“Stay...”

My breath caught in my throat. It was a single
word, but it resonated with an almost magnetic

force. The voice echoed through the basement, growing clearer, layer upon layer, pulsating in time with my heart.

“Stay... with me.”

I shook my head, panic rising as I instinctively knew it wasn't a request but a command. As I turned to Charles, his face reflected the same fear. “I can't do this,” he said, his voice trembling. “Charles, we have to go!” I urged, gripping his arm. But before I could blink, the air around us ignited with a fiery heat, and suddenly, a figure emerged from the shadows. Tall and impossibly gaunt, it seemed to blend

seamlessly with the darkness. Its body shimmered like smoke, yet every crack within it glowed with the intensity of burning coal.

The Ember King.

My heart seized. Its eyes—two hollow voids—burned with an unfathomable hunger. I felt its gaze drilling into me, pressing against my chest with an overwhelming weight. The whisper coiled around me again, urging me forward, pulling me deeper into the shadows. “Offer me... what’s yours.”

“No!” Charles yelled, breaking free from my grip. “We can’t!” The figure loomed closer, its form flickering as if caught in a wind that didn’t exist. I felt a warmth, almost inviting, but I could sense the malice beneath it. The air crackled with an energy that demanded something from us, something dark and terrible. “Run!” I shouted, grabbing for Charles again. But before we could escape, the cabin itself roared to life as the walls seemed to shift. The symbols carved in the wood began to glow, brightening until they were blinding. The shadows thickened and twisted around us, forming a barrier that pulsed with life. “Don’t let it speak!” I shouted, the weight of Grandpa’s

words echoing in my mind. The Ember King began to move, its form flowing like molten lava. “You are mine,” it hissed, the ground trembling beneath us. We turned to flee, but the stairs caved, the wooden steps splintering. “Jake!” Charles cried, looking back at me, panic etched across his face. In a moment of desperation, I flung myself at the door, twisting the knob frantically. But it wouldn’t budge, as though bound by some unseen force. The whispers surged around us, growing louder, more insistent.

“Let me in!”

“Light the fire!” I yelled back at Charles, who stood paralyzed by fear. “Make an offering — it said it wanted smoke!”

Charles hesitated, but the tangible dread in the air snapped him into motion. We stumbled backward into the depths of the basement, searching frantically for something — anything — to help us evade the hungry presence looming before us. In the corner, a pile of wood lay stacked beneath a thick layer of dust. I scrambled, tearing at the dried limbs and pulling them closer as Charles produced a pack of fire starters from his bag. “Here!” he shouted, his voice barely piercing through the

oppressive air. I quickly jumbled the wood together, a crude altar formed of fear and desperation. "Come on, light it!" I shouted. With shaking hands, Charles struck a match, the flame leaping up. I felt a rush of heat, a defiance against the looming presence. As the fire caught, the warmth spread through the basement, chasing shadows back and igniting the air with a fierce glow. "Offer it!" I croaked, my voice raspy. "Offer it something, anything!" Holding my breath, I watched as Charles hesitated for just a moment, then thrust the pack of tobacco into the flames. The smoke spiraled upward, curling in the air like a serpent. The Ember King recoiled, the glow of

its form flickering. “More...” it hissed, its voice edging toward a wail. The air turned electric, crackling with energy as we desperately looked for anything else to feed the flames. “Jake, I can’t—” Charles began but the words froze on his lips. “I’ll take the first watch,” I snapped, realizing the violence of the shadows began to encroach again. “I’ll keep it at bay!” “No!” he protested, but I was already stepping toward the force that surged.

In a sudden burst of defiance, I lifted the journal and held it toward the Ember King, the scraps of the text flickering with the light of the fire. “This is your legacy!” I shouted, the fury

surging in me. “You will not take us down!” The Ember King let out a piercing scream, its form undulating and splitting as if trying to escape the illumination pushing against it. “You—cannot control it!” The fire burned brighter in response, enveloping the journal in flames. But it was too late. The whisper rang out in the darkness, and I realized the journal was never meant to be an offering; it was a summoning. The walls of the cabin began to tremble, the old wood groaning as the foundation cracked. We were caught in a battle for our souls, for our very existence, and the weight of our grandfather’s legacy screamed through the ashes. “Run!” I bellowed, pulling Charles

toward the door as the barriers began to tremble and splinter.

But the flames roared higher, and the shadows grew long, waiting for our moment of weakness.

The Price of

Silence

The morning light filtered through the curtains, but it felt muted, dull, as though stripped of color. My heart raced as I awoke, the remnants of the nightmare clinging to me like a shroud. I had returned to the cabin in my dream, the walls alive with whispers, shadows flickering like errant flames.

As I sat up, the weight of dread settled heavily upon me. It was too quiet. The almost rhythmic sound of my wife's breathing was absent, replaced by a consuming silence that buzzed in my ears. I blinked, trying to clear the remnants of sleep, but my head felt thick, as though wrapped in cotton.

I reached for my hearing aids, fumbling through the clutter on my bedside table. The familiar, comforting sensation of them in my ears was now replaced with an unsettling glitch. As they powered on, a series of sharp static bursts punctured the silence, making my heart race faster.

“Charles?” I called out, my voice hoarse, echoing slightly in the stillness. But I could barely hear it, the sounds distorted and distorted, like a radio losing reception.

I stood up, the floorboards creaking underfoot. It felt like stepping into a dream, the air thick with disquiet. I rushed to the living room, my pulse quickening with every step. Something

was off—too still, too quiet. The clock on the wall ticked loudly, each second like a drumbeat echoing through the void. I fumbled with my hearing aids, turning them up, but the world around me warped further. I could hear the refrigerator humming, but mixed in with that were whispers—hushed tones swirling just beyond my grasp. Glancing down the hallway, I felt a flicker of movement in my peripheral vision.

Shadows danced along the walls, darting away as I turned to face them. I blinked, shaking my head as if to dispel the illusions. But as soon as I focused, the movements were gone, replaced by the everyday stillness

of my home. There was an erratic glitching in my hearing aids, a repetitive crackle that made ordinary sounds distort into something eerie. The boys' laughter from last night replayed in reverse—a broken sound loop that echoed back, twisted and cruel. I pressed my fingers against the devices, trying to adjust the settings, but all I got was more static, the whispers growing louder, weaving themselves into the fabric of my reality. "Focus, Jake. Just breathe," I muttered to myself, heading toward the kitchen, seeking the comfort of routine. As I walked, I noticed small inconsistencies—the photographs were askew on the wall as if someone had reached out to move them while

I slept, and the air felt charged, almost electric. The door to the basement was slightly ajar, and a strange unease crawled up my spine at the sight. In the kitchen, the coffee pot sat silent on the counter, untouched. I flicked the switch and waited for its comforting gurgle, but the machine only coughed faintly, sputtering with a dry gurgle before going quiet. I stood in the stillness, realization creeping in as the world around me felt less like a sanctuary and more like a cage. I grabbed the coffee jar, feeling the ceramic's cool weight beneath my palm, and poured a cup. But as I brought it to my lips, the taste was bitter, acrid, as if it had gone stale overnight. "Something is wrong," I

whispered, the sound barely escaping my lips. The words echoed back with a mocking tone, the laughter of ghosts lurking in the corners of my mind. I reached up to rub my temples, the noise in the back of my head humming with dissonance. With a deep breath, I tried to ground myself. I needed to focus. Just hold on. But as I stepped back into the living room, I caught a glimpse of the curtains fluttering as if blown by an unseen wind, and my heart seized. The house shouldn't feel this way. It should be safe—normal. Then I noticed the shadows pooling on the floor, creeping closer, tendrils of darkness curling like smoke. The light from outside felt dimmer, even as bright

streaks of sunlight should have flooded the space. A wave of dread washed over me. “Charles!” I shouted again, but my voice felt distant, muffled, lost in the distorted cacophony echoing within my hearing aids. I glanced out the window, hoping to gain some sense of clarity. The street outside appeared blissfully mundane, neighbors walking their dogs, children laughing, yet the scene felt unreal — like a meticulously crafted facade hiding something sinister beneath. As I stumbled back, the whispers intensified, swirling around me with a low hum, almost indistinct yet impossible to ignore. They twisted into phrases I couldn't quite grasp, and

with each syllable, I felt my panic rising. I rushed back to the hallway, my heart pounding like a drum. The basement door loomed larger, beckoning me with an inviting chill that seemed to whisper my name. I took a hesitant step toward it before halting, recalling Grandpa's warnings.

Don't let it speak.

Suddenly, the door creaked slightly, pushing open an inch as if something beyond awaited me. I could feel a pull, a desire to lean closer. "Stay away," I warned myself, voice barely a whisper as I stepped back, shaking my head

fiercely. But the whispers kept rising, louder now, chanting and calling, mingling with the static in my ears. They became clearer, drowning out the mundane world, swirling into chaotic cries echoing through my mind. “Smoke... Come to us...” I stumbled back into the living room, the mantra repeating in my mind as I fought to regain control. Gripping the walls, my breathing quickened. The shadows thickened, creeping toward me as I pressed against the cold surface of the window. I had to silence them. I had to—

The sudden crackle of electricity surged through the room. The lights flickered violently, plunging me into darkness for a heartbeat

before they sparked back to life. The air felt alive with tension, thick and electric as an unseen presence pressed against me. And then, the soft whisper returned, now intimate, almost comforting — a voice that echoed through the dark like the embrace of an old friend.

“Let me in.”

The words crawled over my skin, and in that moment, I knew.

The Ember King was closer than I dared imagine.

The Reckoning

The air felt thick with electricity as we pushed our way outside, a desperate plea to escape from the darkness that chased us. The door slammed shut behind us, resonating like a final tolling bell, and yet the echoes of The Ember King's voice hung in the air, lingering like smoke that refuses to disperse.

"What was that?" Charles breathed, his face pale as he looked back at the cabin. I could see the fear etched in the lines of his brow, mirroring my own turmoil. The light from the dying embers spilled out into the night, casting long, flickering shadows that danced against the trees — a macabre play of light and dark. "We can't let it win," I said, forcing my voice to

steady even as I fought against the encroaching dread. "We have to find a way to stop it."

Charles nodded, but uncertainty clouded his features. "How do we fight something like that? It was—" "Powerful," I interrupted, the memory of its form seared into my mind. "But we have to remember what Grandpa wrote. He felt it. He described it. There must be something we can use, something in the journal that can help." Swallowing hard, I turned back to look at the cabin, its windows dark and foreboding, exuding a quiet menace. "We need to go back inside. It's the only way." The notion made my stomach churn. I wanted

to scream at the shadows that seemed to pulse in response to my fear.

“Are you sure?” Charles asked, hesitating as a gust of wind rustled the trees above us. “There are answers in there we haven’t uncovered yet. We can’t run from this.” With a shared look of resignation, we returned to the door, our footsteps weighed down by uncertainty. I reached for the knob, and it turned under my grasp to our surprise, the door creaking open with a will of its own. The air felt heavy as we stepped back inside, shadows wrapping around us like a cold embrace. The basement was still, but the air hummed with an unseen energy. As the door swung shut behind us, the

quiet returned, thicker and more oppressive than before. The last remnants of the fire flickered weakly, casting a dim light upon the symbols etched into the walls.

“Look,” Charles whispered, pointing towards the journal lying on the table. Its pages flickered, whispering secrets, each crease a testament to our grandfather’s unraveling mind.

I approached it cautiously, almost reverently, feeling the weight of legacy pressing down on me. “We need to find what he wanted us to see,” I murmured, remembering the urgency that had colored his final entries.

As we rifled through the pages, the room felt constricted, the shadows pressing closer. I stumbled across a particularly frantic entry, the handwriting resembling a scrawl more than legible words.

The fire speaks... it binds us in ways I cannot comprehend. Offerings are demanded. I can't protect them. I can't protect myself. They come through—the shadows watch, whispering secrets of what I've done...

The words sent chills racing down my spine, resonating with desperate urgency. "Charles, this is it," I said, barely able to keep my voice steady. "He was trying to warn us about making offerings, about how it controls and

consumes.” The air changed, thickening as reality warped around us, shadows stretching in impossible directions. A low hum began to echo in my ears, like a chant vibrating through the very wood of the cabin.

“Jake, do you feel that?” Charles asked, his voice trembling. I nodded, eyes scanning the room for the source of the encroaching dread.

“It’s like it’s alive.”

And then I saw it—a shadow darting just beyond the periphery of my vision, flitting among the clutter. It was fleeting, but its presence was unmistakable, a dark figure flitting between the corners of the room. I felt my heart drop into my stomach. “I can’t stay

here,” Charles said, his voice breaking. “We can’t—”

Before he could finish, the shadows churned, swirling together into a form that clawed at the edges of reality. The Ember King.

The creature emerged from the darkness, its figure coalescing in the low light, hovering just beyond our grasp. It seemed to pulse with a fiery glow, the ember light flickering ominously. “Why do you resist?” it hissed, the words curling in the air like smoke. “You cannot escape what has been written.” I stepped back, heart hammering in my chest. “We’re not afraid of you!” I shouted, forcing the conviction into my voice, though inside I felt as if I were

unraveling. The Ember King's hollow eyes flared with menace. "You think you can outrun your own shadows? The cost must be paid. You must sacrifice..."

"Stop!" I yelled, but my voice seemed small in the face of this ancient power.

"Give me what is owed," it demanded, advancing, the shadows thickening around it like a cloak. "Only then will you understand the truth."

In that instant, I realized what it meant—its hunger demanded something deeper, something more personal. "No!" I cried, instinctively taking a step back. "We won't give in to you!" But the ember glow surged,

illuminating the room with a blinding light. “You will pay—one way or another.”

The ground trembled, and I felt the walls press in, as if they were closing around us. A primal scream erupted from my throat as I lunged for the journal.

“Burn it!” I shouted, throwing the pages into the flickering ember light.

The flames roared, crackling and spitting as the journal caught fire. The air filled with the acrid scent of burning paper, thickening the atmosphere.

In that moment of chaos, I noticed Charles had fallen silent, his face pale as he watched the flames. The Ember King recoiled, its form

flickering uncertainly, shadows writhing in conflict. "If we keep this up, we can drive him away!" I screamed, urgency flowing through me. I pushed Charles toward the flame. "Join me! He can't take us if we fight together!" But the creature lunged again, faster this time. Shadows lashed out, wrapping around us, a cold touch creeping beneath my skin. Charles stumbled back, fear etched across his features. "We can't let it take you!" I shouted, my heart racing. "Throw in the other journal! Anything, just feed the fire!" As the flames licked higher, smoke curling around us, I felt a surge of desperation wash over me. This wasn't just a fight for survival. It was a battle

against the darkness that sought to claim all we held dear. “No more!” I declared, gripping the items scattered on the table. One by one, I hurled them into the fire: a small carving, a token from our childhood, anything that would burn and serve as an offering.

The Ember King shrieked, a sound filled with pure rage, its form flickering as if it were being drawn back into the shadows. “You cannot escape your destiny!”

I felt a rush of adrenaline. “We can make our own destiny!”

With the last remnants of my courage, I shoved the journal deeper into the flames. The

fire roared higher, engulfing the darkness, consuming its power.

And then, in an instant, everything went still.

The fire blazed, but the air around us felt heavy, as if the world had drawn its breath.

The shadows recoiled and twisted, retreating into corners, leaving only the faint glow of embers flickering in the hearth.

I stood there, breathing heavily, chest heaving.

Aftershocks of fear rippled through me, but the oppressive weight had lifted.

But as I turned to look at Charles, ready to share a moment of relief, I could see the panic clouding his eyes. "It's not over," he whispered, a tremor in his tone. "What do you mean?" I

asked, peering into the dim corners of the basement, unease creeping back in. And that's when I felt it—a soft whisper curling around my heart, echoing what I feared most.

The Ember King's presence lingered in the air, a silent promise that this was only a temporary reprieve. As I stared into the dying embers, a chilling thought crossed my mind: the fight was far from over, and the true nature of the darkness was still ahead of us.

Alden Esterhuizen
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